

This project explores the factors that influence daily rural wage rates across 19 Indian states for the year 2022–2023.

Using statistical methods in R, the study aims to build a model that explains variations in wage rates using different variables provided in the dataset.

Econometrics Project

Group-4

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ABSTRACT

This paper looks into the Net State Value Added (NSVA) of various industries, the State Rural Wage Rate, the correlation between them and whether there is any causal relationship. Regressing the given database, we find that a correlation exists between rural wage rate and population, NSVA Agriculture, Industries and Construction. The team attempted to study the impact of the growth of various sectors of the economy on rural livelihood.

Upon exploring reasons behind the correlation, we find that factors such as agricultural productivity, construction sector growth, urbanisation, and literacy also majorly contributed to the rise in rural wages. As the growth of the rural wage rate shows relationships with all of the above factors, we find that states like Kerala witness higher wage rates and better overall quality of life, whereas states with rapid economic growth like Gujarat have lower wage rates and higher rural poverty, proving that rural wage rate is not solely dependent on agrarian economic growth.

Across all regression models, the net sectoral value added in construction and agriculture emerges as consistently significant. Higher construction activity is positively associated with increased real wages, reflecting the sector's stronger wage structure.

In contrast, greater agricultural output is linked to lower real wages, aligning with typically lower compensation in that sector. These findings emphasize the critical role of economic sector composition in shaping regional wage outcomes.

INTRODUCTION

This paper follows the definition of rural as follows – a rural area or a countryside is a geographic area that is located outside towns and cities. Typical rural areas have a low population density and small settlements. Agricultural areas and areas with forestry are typically described as rural, as well as other regions lacking substantial development.

Understanding rural wage rates is critical for assessing the health of the rural economy in India. Wages in rural areas not only reflect the livelihood and well-being of a significant portion of the population but also serve as indicators of labor market dynamics, agricultural productivity, and regional development. In a country where nearly two-thirds of the population still resides in rural areas, analyzing the determinants of daily rural wage rates provides valuable insights into socio-economic inequalities, employment trends, and policy effectiveness.

This project aims to explore the factors that influence rural wage rates across 19 Indian states for the year 2022–2023 using available data. By constructing a regression model utilising R and RStudio, we seek to identify key explanatory variables that help explain wage variation across regions.

India's economy pre-independence was primarily driven by exporting agricultural produce and exploiting farmers. Post-independence, growth depended on primary sectors, but despite green revolution schemes, India pursued growth in manufacturing and tertiary service sectors, leading to a decline in agriculture input and a sharp drop in employment. The share of total employment in agriculture declined from 73 per cent in 1950 to about 46.1 per cent in 2023-24; but this decline has been much slower than the corresponding decline in the share of agriculture in GDP over the same period (from 59 per cent to 16 per cent).

Rural Persons	1999–2000	2004–05	2009–10	2011–12
Agriculture	76.3	72.65	67.94	64.1
Manufacturing	7.41	8.08	7.17	8.64
Construction	3.27	4.87	9.39	11.05
Finance	0.34	4.62	0.59	0.79

Distribution of Workers in percentage by Industry Groups

Although agriculture remains to hold most of the rural workforce, other secondary and tertiary industries are not lagging behind. As the line between rural and urban starts blur with construction, roadways and banking infrastructure, the workforce has gradually redistributed among these sectors. Ideally, these factors should lead to a sharp rise in wages.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Impact of Net State Value Added (NSVA) by Construction sector on Rural Wage

The **Net State Value Added (NSVA)** from the construction sector significantly influences rural wages in India through various channels.

1. Employment Generation in Rural Areas

The construction sector is a major employment provider, particularly for the rural workforce. As of 2023, it employed approximately 71 million individuals, with projections indicating this number will exceed 100 million by 2030. A substantial portion of this workforce comprises rural labourers who migrate to urban centers or engage in local construction projects. The increased demand for labour due to growth in the construction sector can lead to higher rural wages.

2. Impact on Wage Levels

The expansion of the construction sector elevates the demand for both skilled and unskilled labour. This heightened demand can result in increased wage levels, particularly benefiting rural workers who constitute a significant segment of the unskilled labour force. For instance, the Indian government periodically revises minimum wages to address rising living costs, directly affecting rural labourers. In September 2024, minimum wages for unskilled workers were increased to ₹783 per day, reflecting efforts to keep pace with inflation.

3. Skill Development and Wage Disparities

Despite the sector's growth, a notable portion of the construction workforce remains unskilled. As of 2023, only 19% of the workforce was classified as skilled, with the remaining 81% being unskilled. This skill gap can lead to wage disparities, as skilled workers command higher wages. Addressing this through targeted skill development programs could enhance wage prospects for rural labourers.

4. Regional Variations in NSVA and Wages

Data from the Reserve Bank of India indicates significant regional variations in NSVA from construction. For example, in 2021-22, Andhra Pradesh reported an NSVA of ₹49,58,010 lakh, while Bihar's was ₹34,54,088 lakh. These disparities suggest that states with higher construction activity may offer more employment opportunities and potentially higher wages for rural workers.

5. Government Initiatives

Programs like the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) provide rural households with guaranteed employment, often in construction-related projects. This not only offers immediate wage benefits but also helps in skill acquisition, potentially leading to better-paying opportunities in the future.

Impact of Net State Value Added (NSVA) by Industry sector on Rural Wage

As per Himanshu and Kundu, 2016, Net State Value Added (NSVA) reflects the economic output of a state, and when broken down by industry, it can provide insights into the relationship between different sectors and rural wages. A strong industrial sector, especially in areas with high rural labour participation, could potentially lead to higher overall wages, including for rural workers. However, the specific impact depends on various factors like productivity, labour market dynamics, and the nature of jobs created.

1. Rural Wages and Economic Activity:

The relationship between NSVA and rural wages is complex. For example, As per the Ministry of Finance, a strong agricultural sector (part of the NSVA) could support higher rural wages, but it also depends on factors like agricultural productivity and non-agricultural opportunities.

Impact of Net State Value Added (NSVA) by Agriculture sector on Rural Wage

The relationship between rural wages and agricultural productivity has long been a subject of interest among development economists, particularly in agrarian economies like India. Since agriculture remains a labour-intensive sector and a vital source of rural employment, understanding how rural wage levels affect agricultural output—measured here by Net State Value Added (NSVA)—has both economic and policy significance.

1. Cost-Push Perspective

The **cost-push theory** posits that increasing rural wages raise the cost of agricultural production, potentially reducing net value added unless there are concurrent improvements in productivity. Binswanger and Rosenzweig (1986) argued that as rural wages rise, particularly in developing countries, the profitability of agriculture tends to decline. This leads farmers to either mechanise or reduce labour-intensive activities.

2. Wages as a Driver of Productivity

On the other hand, a growing body of research suggests that **higher wages could improve labor efficiency and motivation**, potentially enhancing overall productivity. According to Himanshu, Lanjouw, Murgai, and Stern (2013), the rapid increase in rural wages between 2007 and 2012 in India led to moderate improvements in working conditions and, in some cases, farm productivity.

However, these gains were **not uniform** across regions and were influenced by state-level infrastructure and agricultural practices.

3. The Consumption Effect

Another important angle is the **consumption effect**: Rising rural wages increase household incomes, which can stimulate **local demand** and **economic growth**. Yet, as noted by Chand (2017), this indirect benefit takes time to translate into improved NSVA—especially if **input costs rise faster** than the output value.

4. Regional Heterogeneity

A critical insight from regional studies is the heterogeneity in the wage-output relationship across Indian states. In Punjab and Haryana, where mechanisation and irrigation are prevalent, agricultural output is less sensitive to wage fluctuations. Conversely, in labour-intensive states such as Bihar and Odisha, wage shocks have a more pronounced impact on agricultural value added (Dev, 2018).

5. Role of Capital-Labour Substitution

The elasticity of substitution between labour and capital is another key factor. Narayanan (2017) showed that in sectors where capital can efficiently replace labour (e.g., through mechanisation), the negative effects of rising wages are neutralised over time. However, in low-capital-intensity systems, rural wage increases may suppress productivity unless accompanied by technological or structural reforms.

Impact of Population on Rural Wage

The relationship between rural wage rates and demographic factors, especially population, is a key area of study in labour economics and rural development in India.

1. Theoretical Background

- **Empirical Challenges:** Studies by Bardhan (1977) and Binswanger & Rosenzweig (1986) show that factors like land distribution, migration, and state policies significantly influence rural wages.

2. Role of Policy Interventions

- **Impact of MGNREGA:** The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act has reshaped rural labour markets by enhancing worker bargaining power and influencing reservation wages.
- **Post-Liberalization Trends:** Himanshu et al. (2013) highlight growing regional disparities and demographic shifts affecting rural wage patterns in the post-1991 period.

METHODOLOGY

Rural wage rate in a country can be influenced by various economic and demographic factors. In our research paper, our focus is on the rural wage rate in India and the economic variables behind it. The dataset consists of rural wage rate (**rwage**) across states of India assumed to be the dependent variable (Y_i). Our research includes four different independent variables (X_i) relevant to the study of rural wage rate in India. The variables are – Population (**pop**), Net State Value Added by Agriculture (**NSVA agri**), Net State Value Added by Industries (**NSVA ind**), and Net State Value Added by Construction (**NSVA constru**).

Variable Determination:

We used the best subset selection in R to determine the most relevant variables. Pop, NSVA agri, NSVA ind, and NSVA constru were selected based on statistical significance and model performance.

Population reflects labour supply and demographic pressure. While a high population can suppress wages due to labour surplus (as per the Lewis model), it can also boost economic activity and bargaining power in more developed or urbanising states.

NSVA by Agriculture indicates sectoral productivity. States with high agricultural output, such as Punjab and Haryana, show higher rural wages due to better infrastructure and mechanisation. Agricultural growth, when tied to productivity, leads to wage improvements.

NSVA by Construction plays a major role in rural employment. The sector absorbs large numbers of unskilled rural workers and is directly linked to wage growth through both private demand and public schemes.

NSVA by Industries represents structural transformation. Its impact on rural wages varies; in some states, industrial growth hasn't translated to wage increases due to low rural participation or skill gaps.

Model Specifications:

We have used four types of regression models to analyse the impact of these variables –

- Linear model
- Log-Lin model
- Lin-Log model
- Log-Log model

1. Linear Model:

The Linear model is used when the relationship between the dependent and independent variables is linear. A one-unit change in an independent variable results in a constant, absolute change in the dependent variable.

This model is useful when you assume a direct and linear relationship between the variables without expecting diminishing returns or exponential growth and excessive correlation between variables. It provides a good benchmark for more complex models.

2. Log-Linear Model:

The Log-Lin model is typically used when the dependent variable (in this case, rural wage) is expected to respond to changes in the independent variables in a diminishing or percentage-based way.

Log transformation of wages allows for a more flexible relationship, especially when there are high variations in wages across observations. Example: If the rural wage increases by 10% for every 1% increase in agriculture's NSVA value-added, the log-lin model will give us a good representation of such a relationship.

3. Linear-Log Model:

The Lin-Log model is appropriate when the relationship between the independent variables and the dependent variable is expected to have diminishing marginal returns, particularly when the independent variables, like population or sectoral contributions, grow rapidly. This model is helpful when the effect of changes in the independent variable diminishes as that independent variable increases.

4. Log-Log Model:

The Log-Log model is used when both the dependent and independent variables are expected to have a non-linear and elastic relationship. This model assumes that percentage changes in both the dependent and independent variables are related in a constant proportion. It's commonly used when both variables exhibit exponential growth or are affected by similar underlying processes. In this model, the coefficients represent the elasticity between the dependent and independent variables.

For example, a coefficient of 0.5 for the effect of NSVA agriculture on rural wages means that a 1% increase in agriculture's value-added results in a 0.5% increase in rural wages.

Model Comparison and Significance:

Utilising all four models to assess rural wage on the variables, we will assess their impact based on measures of goodness of fit such as adjusted R-square and overall p-value.

Our hypothesis is based on standard significance levels, i.e: **$p < 0.05$** or **5%** significance.

Assumptions:

We assume the absence of excessive collinearity among the independent variables to minimise the risk of multicollinearity.

Other limitations, such as model assumptions, data constraints and methodological considerations, were accounted for and acknowledged.

RESULTS

1) Linear model:

$$Y_i = \beta_1 + \beta_2 X_i + \beta_3 X_{2i} + \beta_4 X_{3i} + \beta_5 X_{4i}$$

Where:

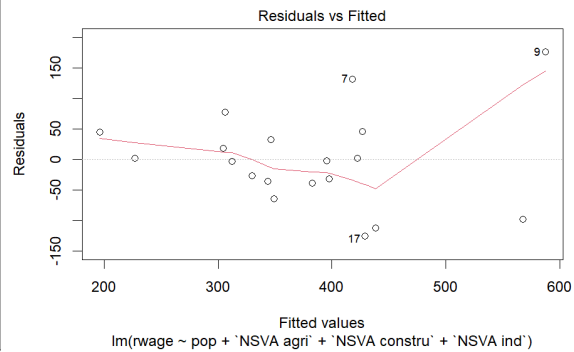
- Y_i = Real Wage (rwage)
- X_i = Population (pop)
- X_{2i} = Net State Value Added by Agriculture (NSVA agri)
- X_{3i} = Net State Value Added by Construction (NSVA constr)
- X_{4i} = Net State Value Added by Industry (NSVA ind)

```
Call:
lm(formula = rwage ~ pop + `NSVA agri` + `NSVA constr` + `NSVA ind`,
    data = projectdata_24_25)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-125.508  -37.052   -2.055   39.480  176.940

Coefficients:
            Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)  4.427e+02  3.489e+01  12.691 4.54e-09 ***
pop          -1.493e-03  8.665e-04  -1.723  0.10681
`NSVA agri`  -6.201e-06  3.285e-06  -1.888  0.07996 .
`NSVA constr` 2.390e-05  6.992e-06   3.418  0.00416 **
`NSVA ind`   -4.338e-06  1.848e-06  -2.347  0.03414 *
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 87.41 on 14 degrees of freedom
(12 observations deleted due to missingness)
Multiple R-squared:  0.6121,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.5012
F-statistic: 5.522 on 4 and 14 DF,  p-value: 0.006987
```



Model Significance:

- **Overall p-value** = 0.006987, confirming that the model is statistically significant.
- However, a small sample size (12 observations) may affect the reliability of estimates.

Explained Variance:

- The model explains **61.21%** of the variation in rural wages (rwage).
- **Adjusted R-squared** = 0.5012, indicating a moderate fit after accounting for the number of predictors.

Predictor Significance:

- **NSVA_constr**: Positive and statistically significant (p = 0.00416).
- **NSVA_ind**: Negative and significant (p = 0.03414), suggesting industrial activity may suppress rural wages.
- **NSVA_agri**: Marginally significant (p=0.07996), contributing weakly to the model.
- **pop**: Not significant (p=0.10681), showing limited explanatory power for rural wages.

Residual Analysis:

- **Residual variance** = 87.41, indicating moderate unexplained variability.
- **Residuals** range from -125.508 to 176.940, suggesting potential outliers influencing the model.

2) Log-Linear Model

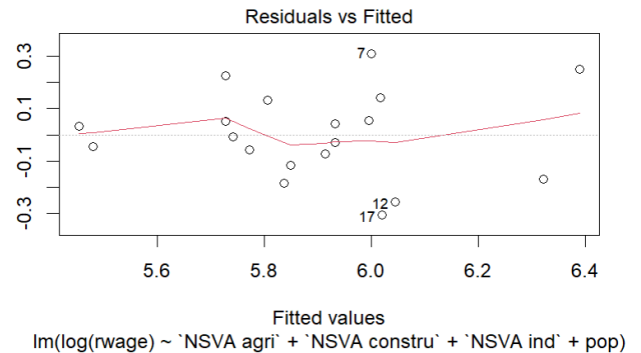
$$\log(Y_i) = \beta_1 + \beta_2 X_i + \beta_3 X_{2i} + \beta_4 X_{3i} + \beta_5 X_{4i}$$

```
Call:
lm(formula = log(rwage) ~ `NSVA agri` + `NSVA constru` + `NSVA ind` +
    pop, data = na.omit(projectdata_24_25))

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-0.304069 -0.095145 -0.007896  0.094309  0.309955

Coefficients:
            Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)  6.054e+00  7.548e-02  80.208  < 2e-16 ***
`NSVA agri` -1.720e-08  7.108e-09  -2.420  0.02968 *
`NSVA constru` 5.396e-08  1.513e-08   3.567  0.00309 **
`NSVA ind`    -9.898e-09  3.999e-09  -2.475  0.02672 *
    pop      -2.946e-06  1.875e-06  -1.572  0.13838
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 0.1891 on 14 degrees of freedom
Multiple R-squared:  0.6613,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.5646
F-statistic: 6.835 on 4 and 14 DF,  p-value: 0.002877
```



Key Interpretations:

Model Significance:

- **p-value** = 0.002877 — model is statistically significant overall.
- Based on **F-statistic** = 6.835 (df = 4, 14) — predictors explain a meaningful portion of the variance in `log(wage)`.

Explained Variance:

- **R-squared** = 66.13% — the model explains a good portion of the variation in `log(wage)`.
- **Adjusted R-squared** = 56.46% — slightly lower, accounting for model complexity and number of predictors.

Predictor Significance:

- **NSVA_constru**: Positive impact (p = 0.00309) — significant.
- **NSVA_agri**: Negative impact (p = 0.02968) — significant.
- **NSVA_ind**: Negative impact (p = 0.02672) — significant.
- **pop**: Negative impact (p = 0.13838) — not significant.

Residual Analysis:

- **Range**: From -0.3041 to 0.3100.
- **Median**: 0.0079 — indicates balanced distribution.
- **Standard error of residuals** = 0.1891 — fairly tight residual spread, suggesting consistent model performance.

Sample Consideration:

- Model based on **19 observations**, with 14 degrees of freedom

3) Linear-Log Model

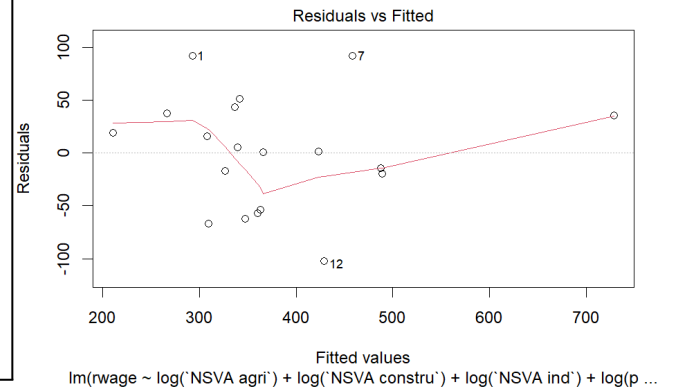
$$Y_i = \beta_1 + \beta_2 \log(X_i) + \beta_3 \log(X_{2i}) + \beta_4 \log(X_{3i}) + \beta_5 \log(X_{4i})$$

```
Call:
lm(formula = rwage ~ log(`NSVA agri`) + log(`NSVA constru`) +
    log(`NSVA ind`) + log(pop), data = projectdata_24_25)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-102.359  -36.593   1.396   36.485   91.884

Coefficients:
            Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)    821.43    234.32   3.506 0.003497 **
log(`NSVA agri`) -127.10    24.44  -5.201 0.000134 ***
log(`NSVA constru`) 175.24    53.42   3.280 0.005474 **
log(`NSVA ind`)  -38.98    43.17  -0.903 0.381878
log(pop)        -48.42    45.27  -1.070 0.302918
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 60.05 on 14 degrees of freedom
(12 observations deleted due to missingness)
Multiple R-squared:  0.8169,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.7646
F-statistic: 15.61 on 4 and 14 DF,  p-value: 4.636e-05
```



Model Significance:

- **Overall p-value** = 4.58e-05, confirming that the model is statistically significant.

Explained Variance:

- The model explains **81.69%** of the variation in rural wages (rwage).
- **Adjusted R-squared** = 76.46%, indicating a strong fit.

Predictor Significance:

- **log(NSVA_constru)**: Positive effect on rwage ($p = 0.00547$), suggesting that higher non-seasonal value added in construction increases rural wages.
- **log(NSVA_agri)**: Strong negative effect on rwage ($p < 0.001$), indicating that higher non-seasonal value added in agriculture tends to decrease rural wages.
- **log(NSVA_ind)**: No significant effect ($p = 0.38188$), meaning industrial activity doesn't significantly impact rural wages in this model.
- **log(pop)**: No significant effect ($p = 0.30292$), indicating that population size does not strongly affect rural wages.

Residual Analysis:

- **Residual standard error** = 60.05, indicating the variability in the residuals.
- **Residual range** = -102.36 to 91.88, suggesting a wide spread and the presence of potential outliers.
- These wide residuals may indicate model misspecification, which could warrant further investigation.

4) Log-Log Model

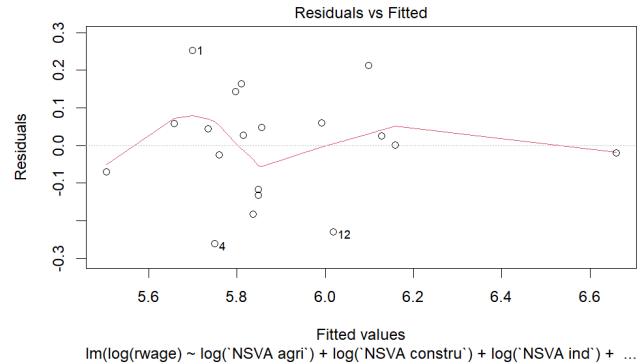
$$\log(Y_i) = \beta_1 + \beta_2 \log(X_i) + \beta_3 \log(X_{2i}) + \beta_4 \log(X_{3i}) + \beta_5 \log(X_{4i})$$

```
Call:
lm(formula = log(rwage) ~ log(NSVA_agri) + log(NSVA_constru) +
    log(NSVA_ind) + log(pop), data = na.omit(projectdata_24_25))

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-0.26061 -0.09262  0.02525  0.05864  0.25244

Coefficients:
            Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept)   6.95413    0.62539   11.120 2.47e-08 ***
log(NSVA_agri) -0.28810    0.06522  -4.417 0.000585 ***
log(NSVA_constru) 0.35839    0.14258   2.514 0.024804 *
log(NSVA_ind)  -0.06063    0.11522  -0.526 0.606969
log(pop)       -0.10186    0.12083  -0.843 0.413406
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 0.1603 on 14 degrees of freedom
Multiple R-squared:  0.7568,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.6873
F-statistic: 10.89 on 4 and 14 DF, p-value: 0.000317
```



Model Significance:

Overall p-value = 0.000317, confirming that the model is statistically significant.

Explained Variance:

- The model explains **75.68%** of the variation in `log(rwage)`.
- **Adjusted R-squared** = 68.73%, indicating a fit after accounting for predictors.

Predictor Significance:

- **log(NSVA_constru)**: Positive effect on `log(rwage)` (p = 0.0248), suggesting that higher construction value added increases rural wages.
- **log(NSVA_agri)**: Negative effect on `log(rwage)` (p = 0.000585), indicating that higher agricultural value added tends to decrease rural wages.
- **log(NSVA_ind)**: No significant effect (p = 0.606969), implying industrial value added doesn't significantly impact rural wages.
- **log(pop)**: No significant effect (p = 0.413406), suggesting that population size does not have a meaningful impact on rural wages.

Residual Analysis:

- **Residual standard error** = 0.1603, indicating the variability in the residuals.
- **Residual range** = -0.26061 to 0.25244, with a relatively symmetric distribution.
- The residuals are well-behaved, suggesting a good fit for the data.

CONCLUSION

Out of the four regression models evaluated, Model 3: **Linear-Log model**, which regresses real wages (**rwage**) on the log-transformed independent variables **log(NSVA agri)**, **log(NSVA constru)**, **log(NSVA ind)**, and **log(pop)**, proves to be the most effective. This model yields the highest adjusted R-squared value of 0.7646, indicating that approximately 76.5% of the variation in real wages is explained by the included variables. It also exhibits strong overall statistical significance, with an F-statistic of 15.61 and a p-value below 0.00005.

The use of log transformations on the independent variables likely helped reduce skewness, improved model interpretability, and addressed potential non-linearity and multicollinearity issues.

When comparing the variables across all models, two emerge as consistently significant determinants of real wages: the Net Sectoral Value Added by agriculture and construction.

In particular, the construction sector (**NSVA constru**) shows a positive and statistically significant relationship with real wages in all four models. This suggests that greater economic activity in the construction sector is associated with higher average wages, possibly due to the relatively higher pay structures in that industry.

Conversely, the agricultural sector (**NSVA agri**) exhibits a negative and statistically significant effect on real wages, particularly in the models using log transformations. This implies that regions with higher agricultural output tend to have lower wage levels, which aligns with the generally lower compensation in agriculture-related occupations.

Overall, these findings highlight the importance of sectoral composition in influencing regional wage outcomes. A greater share of construction-related economic activity tends to drive wage growth, while reliance on agriculture may suppress it.

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